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An executive headhunter revealed how he scouts top talent, and how to be found by him

By Hendrikje Rudnick and Nathan Rennolds, Business Insider Deutschland

"Most of the time, I search for candidates through networks like Xing and Linkedin."

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- **Headhunter Dominik Roth finds executives for companies.**
- **When he looks for new candidates, he often uses networks like Linkedin and Xing.**
- **He told Insider how you can attract headhunters' attention.**

Finding new talent for a company can be quite a tricky task. Finding an excellent manager is even more difficult. That's exactly what Dominik Roth does. He's a headhunter at the human resources and management consultancy Mercuri Urval. There, he searches for executives for corporate clients. As a side job, he offers job application coaching for executives. The expert also runs the podcast "CEO Career Code," in which he provides insider tips for executives. In an interview with Insider, Roth spoke about how he gets candidates noticed and how you can stand out from the crowd.

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"A lot of people think that as headhunters, our job is to find them a new job," Roth said. But he said that assumption is wrong. His clients are companies that hire him to find a new executive. "Therefore, it's much better to be found by a headhunter."

When a company approaches Roth, he begins by establishing some key points. He wants to know what their values are and what exactly they want an executive to bring to their company.

Then his search begins.

"Most of the time, I search for candidates through networks like Xing and Linkedin. In the first round, we contact about 150 to 200 people," he said.

How a headhunter can find you on Linkedin and Xing

If you're ready for a job change and want to be found by a headhunter, be sure to create a profile on career networks, Roth said. According to the expert, two aspects are important — good presentation and findability. The former means having a profile picture and filling out all the important profile descriptions.

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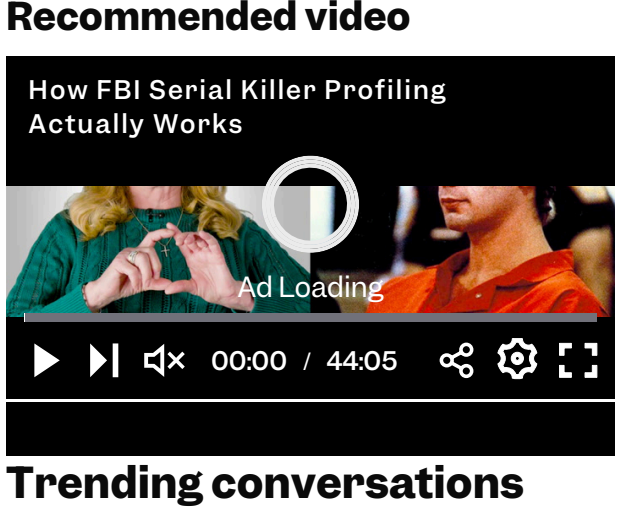

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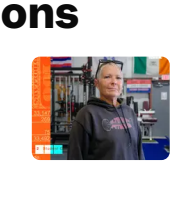

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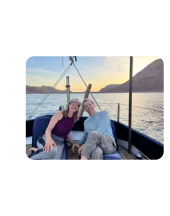

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However, no matter how great your profile is, if you can't be found, it won't do your career much good. The most important thing is to use keywords and specialist terms in your profile and to avoid soft skills.

There are a few key areas to make sure you have filled out.

1. Position

Here it should be clear which position you currently hold, for example CEO or General Manager. You should not write "I run company XY," but use your specific job title.

2. Information or "About" field

This is especially important for findability. Here you should write your position and a short positioning pitch. Include information about what makes you stand out and your goals.

"Something like 'I want to make the world a better place' isn't very meaningful and doesn't do anything for me as a headhunter," Roth said.

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3. Professional experience

Here you can add another name for your position. If you have entered CEO as the position title, you could enter General Manager as the job title here. This will increase your chances of being found.

4. Skills and knowledge

Here, too, you should once again use technical terms.

"Soft skills are not important for headhunters here. We will find that out during the application process. To be found, you should use terms from your industry here," Roth advised.

Headhunters usually use the so-called Boolean search, Roth explained. This refers to a structured search process in which keywords are used to narrow down, expand, or define search results more precisely. So, for example, if Roth is looking for an executive for a software company, he enters various technical terms that are typical for the software industry. If these do not appear in your profile, you will not even make it to the first list.

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Here's how the headhunter search works

After the initial search on social media, Roth contacts up to 200 people to see if they're interested in a selection interview.

"I think it's proper to respond — even if you're not looking for a new job right now. Then you should at least write that you're not open to an interview," he added.

But if there is interest, the headhunter will arrange an initial phone call to clarify whether you fit the specific profile.

These candidates then move on to the next round of selection.

"Here, there's a potential analysis, assessment centers, a personality test, in-depth interviews, and cognitive tests that we conduct," he continued.

As a result, Roth said he has a 94% probability of predicting how managers will behave in certain situations — and whether they'll be a good fit for the company.

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"We then create a long list of ten to twelve suitable candidates after these tests, and then another short list of four to five people who we think would be the best fit for the company," Roth said. In total, this search process takes about eight to twelve weeks.

He then gives the short and long lists to his client, the company that's looking for an executive. After that, there's another psychological assessment. This is where Roth's influence ends. The company alone decides which of the proposals will ultimately be hired.

Provide solutions for the company

As a headhunter, Dominik Roth specializes in CEOs and executives. This means that he primarily looks for people for his clients who already have management experience. Nevertheless, he has a few tips for you even if you haven't quite reached that level yet.

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"In contrast to the management market, there's a shortage of candidates on the specialist market," said the expert. Here, it's worthwhile for you to network with and approach appropriate headhunters.

Roth also recommended submitting speculative applications to your company of choice.

"Many companies are looking for professionals who are innovative and proactive," he went on.

Again, a meaningful profile on a networking platform will help you.

Whether you're at the beginning of your career or have already climbed the career ladder, you should be able to market yourself well and be clear about what you can bring to a company.

"Be a solution provider for the company. What makes you so special in your field? Why should they hire you in particular?" Roth said.

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You should always identify the company's needs so you can go into the interview phase confidently.

And finally, Roth's tip for selection interviews is to "try to find an example to back up any statements you make about yourself."

For example, if you want to convey that you have the ability to deal with conflict, think in advance about a situation in which you've been in conflict, how you acted in that moment, and what the ultimate outcome was. For each characteristic and ability that distinguishes you, you should ideally have an example with situation, action, and result ready. This will increase your chances of mastering the last decisive hurdle in the application process.

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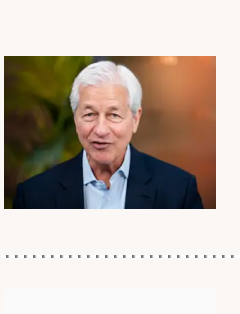

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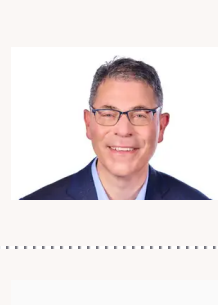

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